Medication Safety: The Five Rights

Every medication administration should satisfy five checks.

1. Right patient - confirm identity before giving any drug.
2. Right drug - read the label, not the box shape or color.
3. Right dose - calculate and double check, especially for children.
4. Right route - oral, topical and inhaled forms are not interchangeable.
5. Right time - follow the prescribed interval, not convenience.

Look-alike and sound-alike drug names are a major source of error.
Store high-risk medicines separately and label them clearly.

Common Medication Errors at Home

The most frequent mistakes reported by pharmacists:

- Taking two products that contain the same active ingredient, for example a cold medicine plus a pain reliever, causing overdose.
- Continuing an antibiotic after symptoms improve, which promotes resistance.
- Using an expired liquid medicine without checking for cloudiness or sediment.
- Sharing prescription medicine with family members.
- Splitting a sustained release tablet, which releases the whole dose at once.

Prevention is simple: read the label every time, keep a written list of current medicines, and ask a pharmacist when two products overlap.

Storage, Disposal and When to Seek Help

Storage:
Keep medicines dry and away from direct sunlight. Most products are stable between 10 and 30 degrees Celsius. A few require refrigeration at 2 to 8 degrees Celsius and must never be frozen. Keep the original packaging and leaflet so the expiry date and ingredients stay available.

Disposal:
Do not flush unused medicines down the drain. Return them to a pharmacy collection point. Never keep expired tablets for a rainy day.

Seek immediate medical help if a person shows difficult breathing, swelling of the face or throat, widespread rash, or loss of consciousness after taking any medicine. These may indicate a serious allergic reaction.